

Chapter 7

Browsing the comics with a paper cup of black coffee – Americano – clutched firmly in his left paw, Liam pursed his lips. Tall Tale comics would ever be one of his favourite little shops slash coffee stops in the town, although he did wish the comic books themselves were not so tempting. The glossy, printed covers called to him and he trailed his fingers longingly over the plastic protective sleeve of one, a rarer edition that had a pretty price tag clipped to the corner. He'd once followed each and every issue of Disturbance with the devoted passion of a long time fan but his wallet laced these days.

Liam frowned, turning his muzzle to the wall as if to ensure his displeasure would not be seen, rudder still against the backs of his thighs. Money was more and more often lingering at the forefront of his mind, dominating his waking thoughts and even, annoyingly, seeping into his dreams. He sighed, recalling the night before when he had woken sweating and in a panic over a problem that was not there. In his dream – rather nightmare – he had been homeless on the street, kicked out of his insufficient flat for not being able to pay the rent. The otter chirped, muzzle dipping sadly. He had not been able to go back to sleep that night. He hated that he couldn't get something off his mind.

The others, just Neil and Pete this evening, had convinced him to join them on a relaxed outing, since it was his day off. Liam had only met up with them grudgingly, the taste of Neil's bile sour in the back of his mouth. There was only so much of the stag he could put up with. The cup of coffee warmed his paws though and he leaned in close to a plexi-glass cabinet of collectables, whiskers twitching. One of the models would go very nicely with his existing set, tucked away in a drawer for safekeeping, all in the original boxes. Unopened too. It was getting to be worth a lot of money now and if he added one more...

Liam shook himself and stepped away from the case. He couldn't afford it. The model wasn't worth it. He knew that. But that didn't make it any less tempting. He sighed, shoulders rolling forward into a slump that he hid under the ill-fitting bulk of his green jacket. Digging his paws into the pockets, his finger wormed into a growing hole in which he may or may not have lost a few precious pennies. Neil would have mocked him if he'd know there was a hole, that he was wearing 'worn' clothes – Liam didn't know how any clothing, bar brand new, could *not* be worn – so the otter counted his blessings that the imperfection was well concealed. Buying a new jacket would scrape away his pitiful savings and he didn't want to paw through charity shop wares for something more in his price range either. They were never much good for clothing.

Tapping the back of his paw, the otter tried to smile. Money, money, money – was there ever anything else on his mind? Scowling at his reflection in the cabinet, distorted, he half-raised a hind paw as if to bring it down to the floor again in a cubbish stomp. *I want it and I want it now!* Instead of giving in to the urge, he pivoted on his heel and flounced back to the cafe section of the shop to flop sullenly into a booth, scooting in and up to the wall.

God damn it... He allowed himself a moment of self-pity. *Did everything have to be so fucking difficult?*

Taking a deep breath, the otter exhaled slowly, breathing out tension and relaxing into the faux leather seat. His back ached and he twisted to reach, rubbing in small circles until the soreness faded, albeit stubbornly. If it wanted to be stubborn, let it. It would go. It had to go.

Although his heart pounded, he knew it would all be okay, because he was in control of it, his money and what he did or did not do with it. He had not bought that model, had he? The otter smiled. That was a triumph. That was a smart move. If he was in control, he had a handle on the ‘to-do’ of the moment. Brightness returned to the otter’s eyes. He’d get by, he always did. An otter had to positive!

He chirped softly as he curled two paws around his cup, relaxing in the meandering buzz of the coffee shop. Another episode of his favourite anime would be available for download later that night, courtesy of Pete’s log-in code, of course. He couldn’t abide illegal downloads, even as short of cash as he was.

“You enjoying yourself there?”

Liam looked up as a shadow fell over him, a taller silhouette blocking out the buzzing overhead lighting strip. The shop was in the process of replacing those. Neil stood with one cocky eyebrow raised as he fingered the tine of one antler. Trying not to frown, Liam’s lips twitched.

“I am, just having a rest,” he said, careful to keep any infection from his tone. “Coffee’s nice.”

“Having a *rest*?”

Neil laughed and shook his head, antlers rattling against a swivelling stand of comics. Pete rubbed his forearm, saying nothing, and slid his gaze away from Liam’s questioning glance, subtle enough to fly under Neil’s radar.

Typical.

“What’s so wrong with that?”

Liam stared down at his coffee. A grimy film was forming on the surface and he grimaced.

“Yeah, I mean,” Neil shrugged, paw lifted up near his shoulder as if to convey confusion, “with all that skating and chasing pucks, it’s no surprise you’re tired. Are you really fit enough to be doing all that crap?”

The otter’s lips tightened into a thin, hard line and he interlocked his fingers over his stomach, skin prickling.

“Is that really any of your business?” He asked, tone dangerously silken as his lips smiled.

As if Liam had raised a fist to him, Neil took a step back, paws held up with the palms facing out towards the otter.

“Now, now,” the stag smirked. “Is there any need for that tone with me? We’re friends. Let’s not be angry at me now.”

Liam tucked his hind paws in close to the seat, striving to ignore how his toes curled inside his trainers. He imagined leaping up and bringing a clenched fist smack bang into into the

smug deer's muzzle, flesh crumpling in. Maybe he'd knock out some teeth. They'd look better scattered over the linoleum.

The otter steeled himself, forming a fist with his paw and releasing his grip over and over again. Pete blinked uncertainly, the badger twisting his paws together. Neil, on the other paw, positively bounced with suppressed glee at Liam's predicament.

Stomach churning, the otter snapped.

"Just what is your problem anyway?"

Neil raised an eyebrow, his favourite look, as his lips quirked up on one side.

"And what does *that* mean?"

The stag countered with a question of his own that didn't really mean anything. Little did he know what fuel he was adding to the simmering fire.

Liam slammed his paw flat on the table. The coffee cup jumped and splattered brown liquid over the previously clean and freshly disinfected surface. Eyes wide, Pete backed up, doing his best to blend into the background with his dark grey and white fur as Liam stood, arms shaking. His rudder slapped the table leg and he ground his teeth together as he leaned forward.

"You know what?" He near enough snarled. "I've had just about fucking enough of this bullshit from you. There's no fucking need for it at all."

Neil visibly balked, eyes but slits as he rubbed the front of his thighs with flat palms. His fingers twitched as if itching to grasp something – but what?

"What's got your goat? Fucking hell." Neil rolled his eyes. "There's always a problem with you, something you have to go off on every single time. Liam, you can't ever take a joke. All the rest of us do, we can take a joke. Why not you? Something you're not telling us?"

Liam scoffed and threw his paws in the air, stepping out of the booth. Noticeably gulping, Neil took another step back, eyes growing wider by the second. The otter's paws twitched, eager for something he could not understand. Not yet. Anger had rarely ruled him in his younger years but the flames flared up quicker and quicker these days. He watched as if from a distance as the stag fumbled, rubbing his throat, and shockingly glanced to Pete.

The otter could have laughed aloud. He wouldn't find much back up when it came to fists there. The badger had a heart of gold. His lips softened. There was not a single sullied drop of blood in the badger's veins.

"I'm sick to my back teeth of you," Liam growled, inching forward on the balls of his paws as if he wanted nothing more than to leap at the stag with his fists flying. "What is *your* problem? I never did anything to you, not ever! Yet you've had something against me since the day we met. What bloody gives?"

The stag crossed his arms and Liam expected him to stomp a cloven hoof like a petulant fawn. Then again, Neil never had played well when denied his toys.

“You need to watch your tone, Reed,” Neil said, using Liam’s surname. “I don’t take bullshit like that from anyone, least of all a penniless scrap like you.”

That stung.

“What’s that got to do with you?” Liam fought to keep himself in checking, shifting his weight second by second. “You always have something to say about shit you don’t know nothing about?”

The otter swallowed, chest tighter than he would have liked to admit. How had the day gone so sour so quickly? The stag tipped his antlers threateningly, light shining off the polished tines, and Pete shrank into the background behind Neil’s shoulder, paws twisting and twisting and twisting together. A pang of guilt struck Liam in the stomach, a physical twinge. He shouldn’t have made the day so hard on the badger. He’d done no harm. He didn’t deserve to be in the middle of everything. The otter swayed, swamped by a sudden wave of tiredness.

“So why bother focusing on me and my problems like they personally affect you, if your life is so much better than mine?” He said more quietly, bitterness rimming his voice. “I haven’t done anything, nothing at all, not to you. So what on earth was ever the big problem?”

Liam trailed off, tirade ending with less of a punch than he had begin with. The coffee shop around him was silent and every patron’s eyes were locked on him and Neil, unwavering in their intensity. The otter froze, a deer in the headlights, as his heart hammered. Thud, thud, thud, thud, *thud*. Blood pounded in his ears, a dull roar that clouded his thoughts. A spoon clinked against a cup as an elderly wolf stirred her tea, surely cold for the length of time she had been staring rudely at the ranting otter flailing his paws about her favourite coffee shop like a loon. She shook her head, disapproval pouring over her spectacles.

Gulping, the otter looked down at his paper cup. Perhaps it would have been better if he’d kept his gob shut. What a fool! What head he done? Why had he done it? He hadn’t *had* to lash back at Neil, as idiotic and rude as the buck had been. The stag smiled superiorly, grin not reaching his eyes, while Liam coughed into his paw and willed the eyes away, sweating enough to soak through his t-shirt.

Neil’s smirk grew and he cocked his antlers at a jaunty, cheerful angle.

“Cat got your tongue?” He mocked. “Maybe you shouldn’t’ve gone off on one.” He set his shoulders back. “When will you learn? I believe you owe me an apology.”

Liam’s eyes darted between Neil to Pete, the caged animal thrust into an unknown world. Of course, he’d been in the coffee shop many a time but in the moment it could not have been more alien. A leopard shook her head and tutted at him, tongue clicking against the roof of her mouth. Her hoop earrings jangled, gaudy pink with cheap sequins.

There was no escape. The otter’s mouth was dry – too dry. He licked his lips, retreating into himself. Neil stared him down.

“I don’t think he needs to apologise.”

Heads turned. A tawny-furred lion popped his head around a swivelling rack of comics, lips parted in a friendly grin that seemed out of place in the tense situation. Regardless, he broke into the conversation, stepping up behind the deer. Towering over Neil, the lion folded his arms, mane ruffled. Liam stared, dumbfounded, wracking his brain for any explanation – anything at all – that may explain why the lion had stepped in. Was he defending him? Would he back up Neil?

The deer and badger shuffled aside, allowing the taller lion access to the otter as the stag eyed him up and down, taking his measure and disliking what he saw. Heart beat returning to a somewhat normal pace, Liam blinked and uncurled his paws from fists. When had he clenched them so tightly? Half-moons from his nails remained cut into his palms. Just where on earth did he know the lion from? He had to have seen him somewhere! But where?

“Hey,” the lion said, extending his paw towards him. “Remember me?”

Taking his paw in a light shake, Liam scratched the back of his head and chuckled half-heartedly. Well, if he was honest...

The lion matched his chuckle.

“Timon.” He tapped his chest. “From the rink.”

Liam scratched his arm. He’d seen lots of lions at the rink. How was he supposed to remember just the one? He looked down at his trainers. There was a splash of coffee on the right one, a brown smudge marking the already dirtied surface. Liam stifled a sigh. He’d tried so hard to keep the blasted things clean this time.

Timon could not be fazed by his silence, however, and gave the otter a winning smile.

“Ice hockey practice,” he kindly elaborated. “I know it’s tricky to tell faces apart sometimes with the helmets off.”

Of course! Liam saw the lion with the easy smile stalking across the changing room again, a sinuous sway to his tail as if suddenly serpentine. Liam blushed. His backside had looked amazing when he’d been getting changed, taking what the otter had thought was longer than necessary to get his trousers back on.

Trying not to think of the lion’s arse, Liam crossed his arms loosely over his chest, mimicking the lion’s pose as he tucked his shaking paws away. No need for him to see his nerves. He pushed the tremors down and locked them under a hatch for later. *Public face on now.*

“Oh, yes,” he said, struggling to not look down at his shoes and maintain careful eye contact. “Err... How’ve you been?”

Timon beamed.

“Not bad! But what’s going on here?” He inclined his head back to Neil and Pete, the duo caught by dull silence. “Not exactly the place for a brawl, though you go around the corner and you’ll be in a rough enough area for it. So you’re not too far out of range to play that game.”

He gave a big belly laugh, slapping his leg and returning his paw to the light curve of his stomach. Liam swallowed the lump in his throat and chance a smile, expression instantly lifting. It was hard not to respond to the lion.

“Things are fine,” he said, as matter of fact as possible. “This is Neil and Pete. Neil, Pete – this is Timon...from the rink.”

The otter rubbed the back of his paw surreptitiously, hard nails raking a light line of pain that sharpened his focus. It was not the healthiest way to behave but who would ever know? It was a close kept secret of coping with the day.

Neil coughed and mussed up the thicker fur atop his head, allowed to grow purely so he could style it with gels. The otter wrinkled his nose and stifled a complaint at the scent of fur putty. It was a wonder the young stag wasn’t gay with the amount of fur products he used.

“Right... I think we’ll be leaving you to it,” Neil tipped his antlers towards Timon, “and our other *friend* here with his knickers in a twist well enough alone now.”

He patted the fur between his antlers down.

“Wouldn’t want to disturb the cosy little thing you’ve got going on here...” He shrugged. “Pete. Let’s go.”

The badger looked down at the comic in his paws, sealed in a plastic sleeve. It smelled of newness.

“Sure, I’m going to get this first.” Pete smiled and held the comic up for Liam to see the cover: Raiders of Time. “Want to read it later?”

The otter perked up and exchanged a look with Pete, grin widening like that of a Cheshire cat. Turn down his favourite comic? As if!

Nodding, Liam eased himself completely out of the both to join the rather patient lion in the middle aisle between rows of booths, shoulders loosening. Timon folded his paws over his stomach, a genuine smile fixed on his lips. Liam giggled inwardly. He had not thought that cats were so patient. Not even Timon’s tail twitched.

“I’ll see you next weekend then, probably depends when I’m working.”

Liam half-heartedly waved to Neil, saving the warmth of his farewell for Pete. The stag, however, snorted, phlegm flying from his nostrils crassly.

“We won’t hold our breath – you never turn up when you’ve got work. Too tired and all that jazz.”

Liam stiffened – but it was already too late. Neil ushered the badger away, blocking Liam’s view of his shuffling paws, though the otter chanced he saw Pete look back, perhaps in apology for his abrupt departure. Anger flickered to life, a burning heat licking through his stomach, and the otter dug his nails into the palm of his paw. Again, they bit deep.

Fuck him! He didn’t have to explain himself. Liam shook his head, lost in his own world as anger controlled him like a dog with its master. He should smack his fist into the smug bastard’s face, let that teach him a lesson. He wouldn’t forget it, that’s for sure. Exhaling slowly, the otter rubbed the heat from his muzzle, cheeks warm. The satisfaction may actually be worth it, to put Neil in his place, oh so worth it.

“Hey...are you okay?”

Tim placed a paw on the otter’s shoulder and Liam jumped away as if he’d been electrocuted.

“Yeah... Yeah, I’m fine,” Liam sighed, relaxing every muscle in turn and hoping Timon had not noticed how viciously he’d jumped away, putting it down to surprise. “I’m fine, really. You made me jump there.”

Timon’s tail flicked, the fluffy tip snaking around to bat against the otter’s calf. Liam took a deep breath as the lion eased closer, shielding him from continuing curious stares, the eyes of shop patrons boring into his back. Though he understood why they stared – he would have done the same if their roles had been reversed – Liam wished they’d mind their own bloody business.

“You don’t look very okay. Come on – let’s get out of here. It’s stuffy anyway.”

Leaving his drink regretfully behind – what a waste of money – Liam followed at Timon’s heels, eyes fixed on the smooth black floor. He counted flecks of grey and noted a scrunched up tissue, stained and sopping brown, before the door opened in front of him and fresh air tickled his whiskers once more.

Timon put his paws on his hips and inhaled deeply.

“Whew! That little shop looks nice from the outside but it’s sure not easy to breathe in there.” He brushed out his mane. “Need some space around me.”

Liam studied him out of the corner of his eye, thoughts racing.

“There’s a lot of you to need space.”

The lion laughed.

“Well, I need it for the rink! Speaking of which, are you going to practice next week?”

Liam’s wallet yawned but the lion looked so hopefully expectant that he could not force himself to say no, although he had intended to give it a miss. Hockey had been revealed as a pricey endeavour, though he would never have admitted that to Neil.

“Yeah, I’ll be there.”

“Great!” The lion linked his fingers together in front of his stomach, rising up on the balls of his hind paws, not that he needed the extra height. “But...”

He fiddled with his belt.

“I wouldn’t mind meeting up before then, if you’re available. Are you free any nights this week? I’m off after the usual nine to five work.”

Liam blinked, too stunned to say anything other than the truth.

“I finish at seven on Tuesday. Would that work?”

“That works well for me! We can go chill out a bit. Sure it’ll be more relaxing than your evening here with those two. Some friend that stag seems to be.”

Liam’s lips pressed together but he did not comment.

“I’m sure we can find something to do,” he said hesitantly. “Maybe meet at the rink so we know where we’re at?”

“Works for me! See you then?”

“I will...” Liam still wasn’t completely certain he knew what was happening, swept along by the lion’s natural flow and easy tongue. “So, after work on Tuesday then.”

The lion waved as he said his farewells, disappearing almost as quickly as he had first appeared down the pedestrian street, flanked with shops. Liam raised his paw in goodbye and leaned back against the painted brick wall outside the coffee shop. Struggling to process the events of the rapidly progressing even, he dragged his eyes away from Timon’s retreating backside and slid his gaze up to the twilight sky. Early stars pricked through the gloom, a clear night for once.

It had been a long while since another fur had asked him to make plans.